

You Are Sons and Daughters of God

This has been one of the most exciting things I have entered into. I do not know how to say it, but it has done something to my faith. I think I can tell the difference between my spirit, my soul, and the other operations better than I ever have before.

This last year He has shaken my spirit a couple of times, and whenever that has happened my whole world changed. I think this has changed my world again: understanding covenant versus inheritance, covenant versus sonship.

I have been pouring over verses I have known all my life. As we have taught you to meditate, your soul can reach out and assimilate something. That is why I have taught you to take a small book like John and read it continually, over and over, fifty times, without trying to get anything out of it. Read the verses directly and precisely, acknowledging what is in them.

You may not know what a verse means yet, but you can understand what it says. I remember assimilating Proverbs and reading:

"Where no oxen are, the crib is clean."

You know what it says, even if you do not yet know what it means.

Recently I found out more about how that assimilation process operates. The first verses He picks up are the ones pertinent to the whole outline. He begins lifting verses that form the outline, and you start understanding the mind and heart of the book.

Hebrews is a very difficult book to assimilate. I have come across verses I believed one way all my life, and now I am seeing they were not exactly the way I had believed them. That happens when you begin to assimilate.

This inheritance He has brought me to, this understanding of covenant versus sonship, seems to do the same thing to the few people I have been able to teach it to in detail.

As faith people, we have taught severely on our covenant. So I would run around saying, "I am a covenant man," out of one side of my mouth, and, "I am a son of God," out of the other. But that covenant was fulfilled in sonship.

When God promised Abraham that he would be the heir of the world and that through his seed all nations of the earth would be blessed, the fulfillment of that covenant resulted in adoption and sonship. A son cannot be a slave or merely a servant. He must be an heir.

That changes the way you look at who you are in Christ. He is the oldest living Brother in the body of Christ. When you find out that this comes by inheritance and absolutely cannot be earned, something begins to happen in your faith.

For me, a transformation process took place. Being transformed to sonship seemed to bring me into an existing state of faith that continually knows who it is and receives from God. I do not particularly select times to receive anymore. I know I am a son, and I know I have inherited.

The more verses I uncover, the more I see that the covenant God cut with Abraham for sonship was fulfilled in me when I was born again and adoption took place.

Galatians 3:25 says:

"But after that faith is come, we are no longer under a schoolmaster."

The schoolmaster is a teacher, a tutor. Paul continues:

"For ye are all the children of God by faith in Christ Jesus.
For as many of you as have been baptized into Christ have put on Christ.
There is neither Jew nor Greek,
there is neither bond nor free,
there is neither male nor female:
for ye are all one in Christ Jesus.
And if ye be Christ's, then are ye Abraham's seed,
and heirs according to the promise."

I am a son, and I receive through inheritance. My faith is excited.

Galatians 3:28 is saying the same thing as Second Corinthians 5:

"If any man be in Christ, he is a new creature:
old things are passed away;
behold, all things are become new."

Paul also says:

"Henceforth know we no man after the flesh:
yea, though we have known Christ after the flesh,
yet now henceforth know we him no more."

When he says the old things passed away, he is differentiating between the two covenants. The old covenant passed away, and the new things came as we became new creatures in Christ.

That is why Galatians says there is neither Jew nor Greek, bond nor free, male nor female. It eliminates the background any of us came from, including the Jew. Henceforth we know no man after the flesh, not after national heritage, creed, tongue, race, or bloodline.

God used the nation of Israel to bring Christ into the earth, but now we do not know any man after the flesh. We have all been born again and become the children of God.

If you belong to Christ, then you are Abraham's seed and heirs according to the promise. That is past tense. You have already inherited.

In Galatians 4, Paul begins talking about a man waiting to inherit. In particular, he is dealing with the Jew, because the Galatians were being pressured by Judaism to go back under the law.

Judaism followed Paul from Antioch. When he started the Galatian church, Judaizers followed him there. They would say, "Paul is a good fellow, but he is not instructed in the more excellent way. You Gentiles have become Abraham's seed through Christ Jesus, but that is not what saves you. Now that you are Abraham's seed, you must go on and keep the law to be saved."

Paul was trying to turn the tide of that.

The heaviest chapters leading up to Galatians 4 include the dissimulation at Antioch, when James and elders came from Jerusalem and Peter was caught in hypocrisy. Before they arrived, Peter ate with the Gentiles. I used to picture a banquet, but that was not really the point. Peter was eating Gentile foods.

Remember the four-cornered sheet in Acts? God said, "Rise, Peter; kill and eat." Peter answered that he had never eaten anything unclean. God was showing him that He had cleansed the Gentiles, and Peter was to stop calling them unclean.

Years after Peter was supposed to preach the gospel to every creature, God was still dealing with him over this. So when Peter ate with Gentiles, he was eating what they ate. When James and the elders came, the hypocrisy was that the Jews withdrew from the Gentiles and their foods.

Paul withstood Peter to his face. Imagine one apostle confronting another one. I believe one reason Paul was an apostle born out of due season is that Jesus taught him in the wilderness, and when he came out, he found the other apostles already being pulled back under the law. Paul single-handedly helped turn the church back out of it. Thank God.

When you study the lives of the apostles, where they went and how they died, you find that many of them sought something higher than survival. The martyr's crown was highly acclaimed, but they did not run from martyrdom. They went into foreign cultures knowing they would probably die, and most of them did.

Many were buried on foreign soil, never returning to see their people again. Peter endured terrible imprisonment and was crucified upside down. Paul was beheaded at Rome. Others were stoned, crucified, or killed in other brutal ways.

They did not live as though preservation was the highest calling. But there was an even higher call these men sought: to be called the friend of Jesus. Jesus continued to visit Paul and others in His glorified body because they had forsaken all and received that highly acclaimed status.

Thank God for Paul. Outside of Jesus, he is my hero and my favorite teacher. Next to him is John. John is tremendous. You can see his own revelation in his writings.

Galatians 4:1 says:

"Now I say, That the heir,
as long as he is a child,
differeth nothing from a servant,
though he be lord of all."

In particular, Paul is talking about the Jew here, because the Galatians wanted to go back under the law. He is saying, "You Gentiles want to go back under the law? Then listen to what a man under the law came out from."

The heir is the man standing to inherit the promise God made to Abraham. As long as he is a child, he differs nothing from a servant. God whispered to my spirit, "Son, that word for servant is slave."

I went to the Greek, and sure enough, it was the word for slave. Translators could handle "servant," because Israel truly served in the house of God. But "slave" takes on another status. It means a slave to sin.

Even though Abraham had righteousness accounted to him, he was waiting for the promise like everyone else. He was still a slave in that sense. The heir holding the promise through Abraham's seed was no different than the slave, because both were in bondage to sin.

Paul is saying, "You Galatian Gentiles want to go back under the law and live like slaves, after you have become sons?"

Abraham's righteousness was accounted to him. It was laid to his account to be paid in full at the resurrection of Christ. Accounted righteousness was as good as the real thing. Abraham could resist the devil and charge it to the cross, knowing every righteous charge against that spiritually dead man would be paid in full at Christ's resurrection.

Romans 8 says:

"Likewise the Spirit also helpeth our infirmities:
for we know not what we should pray for as we ought."

The Spirit searches the heart and knows the plan of God. He prays for us according to the will of God, and then we know all things work together for good to them that love God and are called according to His purpose.

Why? Because I have part of my inheritance, the earnest of my inheritance, the Holy Ghost inside me with a supernatural language working the whole plan of God for me.

All I have to do is be bright enough to pray. Pray God's plan, and eventually it will show up. Even the simplest believer cannot stay on the wrong trail very long if he keeps praying in the Holy Ghost, because the plan of God keeps surfacing in his spirit.

Someone may say, "Just eat the hay and spit out the sticks." No. Pray in tongues, and the Holy Spirit becomes the personal illuminator of your spirit. Mysteries begin unfolding. When something wrong is said, something in your spirit reacts, and for survival you leave it.

Some of you come back and say, "Our preacher is preaching differently." He is the same. You are different.

Romans 8:29 says:

"For whom he did foreknow,
he also did predestinate to be conformed to the image of his Son,
that he might be the firstborn among many brethren."

Another place says Jesus is the firstborn from the dead. How could He be firstborn when there were physical resurrections in the Old Testament?

Firstborn from the dead was not primarily talking about the physical body, though the body will be included in the inheritance. It was talking about a man's spirit going from death to life. Jesus was the firstborn from the dead since Adam. He was the first Man to be born spiritually alive and the first Man to be born again out of spiritual death since Adam.

Everyone else had to wait. Those holding the promise were predestinated to the cross, to Christ, so He might be the firstborn among many brethren. Before the Firstborn was born, what image did we have to conform to? We had to wait for that great event.

Old Testament saints waited in Abraham's bosom, a comfortable spiritual place, an Old Testament type of heaven. They could not come into the Father's presence yet, but they waited for the promise God made to Abraham: righteousness would come by faith, not accounted righteousness only, and they would become sons and daughters of God.

When Jesus finished His suffering, He stopped there. He fulfilled what He said:

"The hour is coming, and now is,
when the dead shall hear the voice of the Son of God:
and they that hear shall live."

Those in Abraham's bosom heard His voice. He said, "The time has come for you to leave this Old Testament type of heaven and come home with Me into the presence of the Father, because you are going from death to life as I am going from death to life."

He led captivity captive. What a procession to heaven that must have been.

In John 8, Jesus speaks to Jews who believed on Him:

"If ye continue in my word,
then are ye my disciples indeed;
and ye shall know the truth,
and the truth shall make you free."

We often use that verse to preach the transforming power of the Word, and that is true. But in context, Jesus is speaking to the Jew holding the promise of sonship as an heir. He is saying, "If you continue in My word, you will be My followers indeed. You will know the truth, be born again, and the truth will take you from a slave to a son."

Some Jews answered:

"We be Abraham's seed,
and were never in bondage to any man:
how sayest thou, Ye shall be made free?"

Jesus answered:

"Whosoever committeth sin is the servant of sin.
And the servant abideth not in the house for ever:
but the Son abideth ever.
If the Son therefore shall make you free,
ye shall be free indeed."

The one holding the promise was no different from the slave until the Son made him free.

What purpose did Israel serve? God had to have a client nation. He had to have a nation that could serve in His house to bring salvation into the earth.

Romans 3 says the law cannot save. By the law is the knowledge of sin. The Gentile, uncircumcised by nature, can now do in his heart what circumcision was supposed to point to, because he is born again. The Jew who had circumcision could not keep the righteousness of the law because he was not born again.

When the Gentiles received the same inheritance without keeping the law, the Jews were upset. They had believed the law saved them. Paul says the new nature saves; the law gives the knowledge of sin.

So what advantage did circumcision have? Much every way, because to Israel were committed the oracles of God. God needed a client nation to serve in His house.

But Jesus told Abraham's seed that they were slaves to sin. They could not stay in the house forever unless the final part of Galatians took place in them and they were adopted into God's family as sons and daughters.

In John 8:42-44, Jesus says:

"If God were your Father, ye would love me:
for I proceeded forth and came from God;
neither came I of myself, but he sent me.
Why do ye not understand my speech?
even because ye cannot hear my word.
Ye are of your father the devil."

That is why you had to be adopted. If you are a slave to sin, God is not your Father, and you do not have His nature.

That is also why Jesus told the Samaritan woman:

"The hour cometh, and now is,
when the true worshippers shall worship the Father in spirit and in truth."

That is little "s": out of the human spirit. The Father was not hopping from church to church looking for worshipers. He had sought for four thousand years for people who would be born again, sons and daughters in His house with His nature, back in fellowship with Him.

First Corinthians 15 says the first man Adam was made a living soul, and the last Adam was made a quickening spirit.

When the word "quickenings" is used apart from resurrection language, it pertains to a spirit going from death to life. The first man Adam was made a living soul. God formed his body from the dust of the earth, breathed into him, and Adam became a living soul. His spirit came alive from the breath of God.

Jesus told Nicodemus:

"The wind bloweth where it listeth,
and thou hearest the sound thereof,
but canst not tell whence it cometh, and whither it goeth:
so is every one that is born of the Spirit."

The word for wind is tied to breath. Just as God breathed into Adam and Adam became a living soul, the Holy Spirit breathes life back into your spirit when you are born again, and you become a son of God as Adam was.

After Adam fell, his spirit died, but he remained a living soul, a life-giving soul in the sense that every human spirit produced after him was born spiritually dead.

Then the last Adam came as a quickening spirit. He took the spirit Adam caused to be born dead and brought it back to life. He made me a son of God.

If I am Christ's, then I am Abraham's seed and have inherited according to the promise.

Galatians 4:1-7 says:

"Now I say, That the heir,
as long as he is a child,
differeth nothing from a servant,
though he be lord of all;
but is under tutors and governors
until the time appointed of the father.
Even so we, when we were children,
were in bondage under the elements of the world:
But when the fulness of the time was come,
God sent forth his Son,
made of a woman,
made under the law,
to redeem them that were under the law,
that we might receive the adoption of sons.
And because ye are sons,
God hath sent forth the Spirit of his Son into your hearts,
crying, Abba, Father.
Wherefore thou art no more a servant,
but a son;
and if a son, then an heir of God through Christ."

Because you are sons, God sent forth the Spirit of His Son into your hearts. This sounds like Romans 8.

The Spirit of His Son here is not the Holy Ghost. The Holy Ghost is the third Person in the Godhead. The Spirit of God's Son means you inherited the same spirit and nature Jesus had when He rose from the dead.

As God had life within Himself, He gave to the Son to have life within Himself. When your spirit was quickened, you were given life within yourself. I have the Spirit of Christ, but it is not Jesus' own human spirit. He has His human spirit, and I have mine. The same quickening that happened in Him happened in me because I was quickened together with Him.

Now I have the Spirit of His Son, and that makes me a son of God.

Galatians 4:8-9 says:

"Howbeit then, when ye knew not God,
ye did service unto them which by nature are no gods.
But now, after that ye have known God,
or rather are known of God,
how turn ye again to the weak and beggarly elements,
whereunto ye desire again to be in bondage?"

You did not born God; He borned you. Now that you have been born of Him and become His son and heir, why go back out with the slaves?

Jesus is my oldest Brother in the body of Christ, and He is also my Lord. He was not adopted. He was made to be sin, but He never committed sin. He was the first Man since Adam to be born spiritually alive. Then He was made my sin and quickened again.

I had another master. I was a slave to sin. The devil was my father. That is why I had to be adopted.

Think of adoption papers. Once the covenant is fulfilled, the child does not keep proving he belongs. The covenant between father and child has already been fulfilled in inheritance. The adopted child is bone of my bone, body of my body, with full inheritance.

That is what happened to us. The covenant has been fulfilled. I am a son of God.